

What Is Vietnam's Main Purpose in Buying India's BrahMos Missiles? What Potential Threats Are They Meant to Defend Against?

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Do you even need to ask? It must be to defend against the northern neighbour. Against any other neighbour, Vietnam would not need the BrahMos at all — its domestically made anti-ship missiles would be quite sufficient.

Although the BrahMos is somewhat weaker than the YJ-12 (Eagle Strike-12), offence is always easier than defence. If Vietnam fired a considerable salvo of BrahMos missiles at once, it would still stand a very good chance of penetrating the air-defence systems of the northern great power's warships. India has already completed test launches of the BrahMos-ER, whose range has been extended from 290 kilometres to over 400, with a maximum of 900 kilometres, and whose penetration capability has been strengthened as well. If Vietnam later adopts it, the threat will be even greater. India is also developing the BrahMos-NG, expected to be test-launched this year. This model's range is still only about 300 kilometres, but its speed reaches Mach 3.5 and its stealth capability is greatly enhanced; once it enters mass production it may also be sold to Vietnam, the Philippines, and other countries.

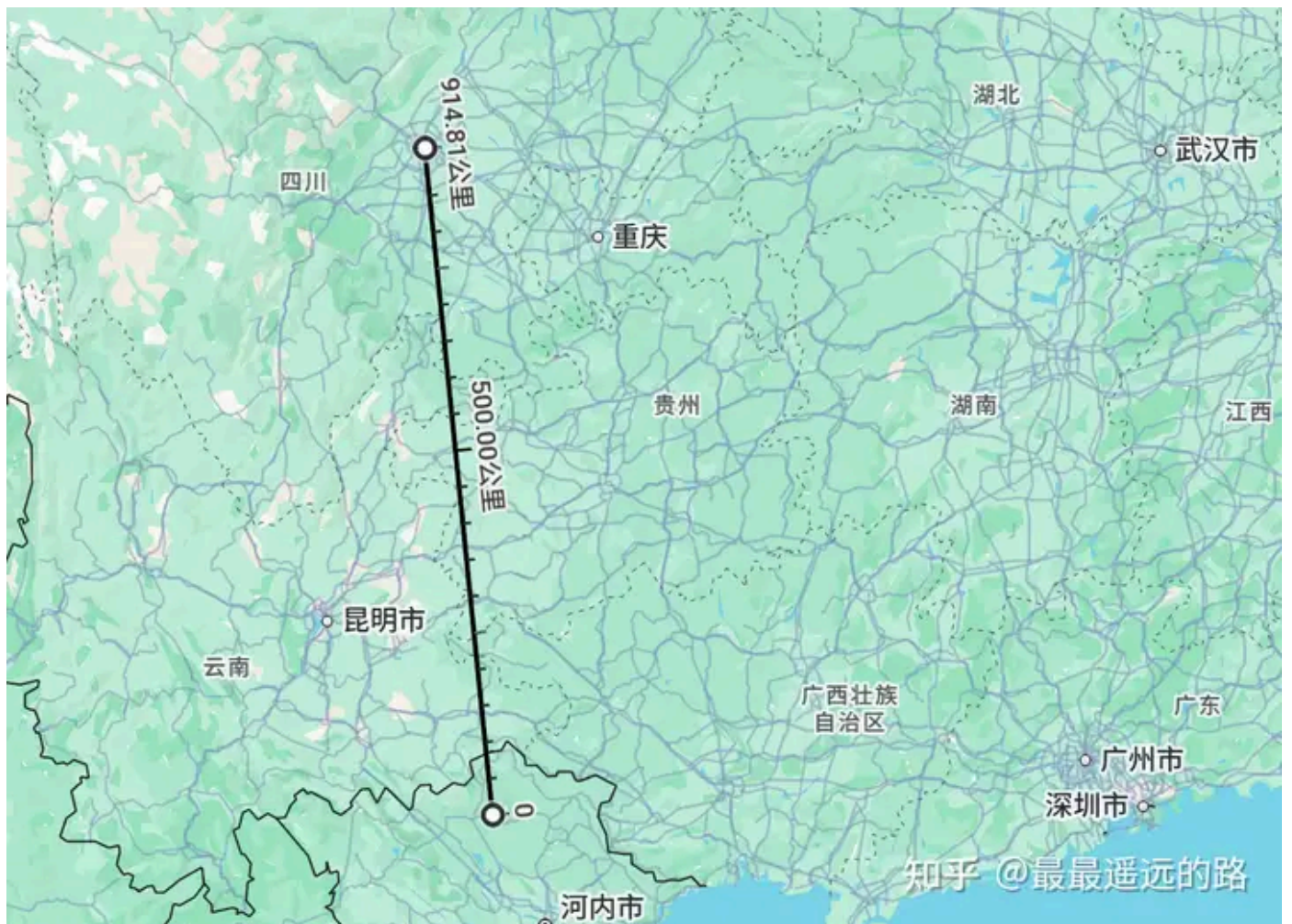


The BrahMos-ER, with a range of 400 to 900 km, can strike the Zhongsha Islands from the mainland

Besides introducing Soviet-made [systems]^{[1][2][3][4]} missiles, Vietnam is also developing its own missiles (including self-developed engines for modified versions of the missiles) and drones; drones in particular have shown their strategic value for asymmetric warfare in the West Asian conflict. Vietnam's newest drone — the MALE drone is a long-range, multi-purpose strategic UAV developed independently by Viettel, Vietnam's military-industrial telecommunications group. The official materials state clearly that this model, like all the drones Viettel exhibits, is 100% Vietnamese-made, covering the entire process from design and research to manufacture. With a range of over 1,000 kilometres, a maximum endurance of 12 to 24 hours, and a payload of about 500 kilograms, it can carry out reconnaissance, precision strike, communications relay, and other missions — one of the largest drones Vietnam has developed on its own. A 1,000-kilometre range means it has the capacity to strike the southern metropolises of the northern neighbour. If Vietnam builds on these self-developed technologies to produce long-range (1,000-kilometre) suicide drones, added to hardened underground bases, it could indeed greatly strengthen its capacity for counter-strikes.



With a range of 1,000 km, the Pearl River Delta is easily reached from Vietnam's heartland



The major cities of the entire southwest region lie within striking range

Drones could also be used to control the shipping lanes of the entire South China Sea, forcing the opponent to commit ground forces and sink into a quagmire

The media always say Vietnam has leaned over wholesale to China. Economically that may be so; but militarily, Vietnam has always kept its distance from the northern great power. Whether through its own research or through cooperation with Russia and India, its goal is to develop a defence capability relatively independent of China. Should it really face external aggression, Vietnam's ballistic missiles and drones could launch large-scale drone and missile attacks on the infrastructure and industrial facilities of China's south and southwest, while using drones to control the South China Sea shipping lanes, forcing the opponent either to stop its aggression and open peace talks, or to commit ground forces. In all likelihood, Vietnam is to be ASEAN's first and strongest line of defence for maintaining its own independence.

Notes

[1] "Vietnam's Ballistic Missile Force Is Not to Be Underestimated" (WeChat article)

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<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/GYXEK5wuRKoiLgzLaBr3Dg>

[2] "Vietnam's First Self-Developed Missile System Unveiled: The 'Truong Son' Coastal Anti-Ship Missile System Officially Made Public" (WeChat article)

中文原文：越南第一款自研导弹系统曝光：“长山”岸舰导弹系统正式公开

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/ydF5zFVDUSGxUIop3F-epQ>

[3] "Vietnam Unveils New Loitering Munition and Reconnaissance Drone, Joining the Ranks of Autonomous Defence Suppliers" (WeChat article)

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<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/Zc1n1-JsVmIsNlBd-UHTrQ>

[4] "Vietnam's Latest Self-Developed Reconnaissance-Strike Drone Makes Public Debut, Its Aerodynamic Layout Rather Similar to Turkey's TB-2": According to Vietnamese reports, the VU-MALE drone has a wingspan of 17 metres, a maximum take-off weight of 1.5 tonnes, a maximum flight altitude of 10,000 metres, a range of 1,000 kilometres, a maximum endurance of 24 hours, and a payload of 500 kilograms. It can carry various electronic equipment and guided weapons for reconnaissance and ground-attack missions, and can also serve as a communications relay providing long-range communications and data transmission for the armed forces. (WeChat article)

中文原文：《越南最新自研察打一体无人机公开亮相 气动布局与土耳其TB-2颇为相似》据越南方面的相关报道称，VU-MALE无人机的翼展为17米，最大起飞重量1.5吨，最大飞行高度10000米，航程1000公里，最大留空时间24小时，有效载荷500千克。该型无人机可以搭载各种电子设备与制导武器，执行侦察与对地攻击任务。此外，该型无人机还能执行通信中继任务，为部队提供远距离通信和数据传输能力。

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